



THE SAMI PEOPLE OF NORTHERN EUROPE live in the Arctic

SAMI

A NOMADIC LIFE IN THE CHILL

area popularly known as Lapland. Originally the Sami hunted reindeer, but by the 17th century, hunting was replaced by herding. These days few

Life in the freezer

In a land where the vital activities of getting food and keeping warm are the difference between life and death—temperatures can plummet to a chilly -49°F (-45°C)—the Norwegian Sami herders live remarkably in tune with the land. For centuries the Sami have formed work teams called *Sii'das*—groups of families that herd their reindeer together and share the work. Each reindeer is marked, according to the *Sii'da*, when it is born, usually by a small nick cut out of one ear.

CLOTHING

Some Sami still wear the traditional bright red and blue costumes. Women wear dresses belted at the waist and men wear belted tunics. In the winter they wear reindeer skins with their clothes. The women use looms made of wood and antler to weave the belts and ribbons that decorate clothes.

A traditional lifestyle does not stop the Sami from enjoying modern conveniences.

Tall hats are sometimes stuffed with grass to help keep the head warm.

BELIEFS

Originally the Sami followed an animistic religion, believing that all objects in nature have a soul that must be respected. This has long been replaced by the Lutheran faith, and marriages take place in churches. However, they still believe that spirits inhabit the natural world and those who do not respect nature will have trouble living off the land.

The Sami people started converting to the Christian faith in the 17th century.

